

PHASE

BRAINSTORMING & IDEATION PHASE

Date	28 September 2026
Team ID	SWTID-2026-5127
Project name	Streamlining IT Procurement: Automating Standard Laptop Orders with Flow Designer
Maximum marks	4

1. Brainstorming Ideation Phase

1.1 Purpose of this phase

The brainstorming phase is where the project idea is born, questioned and shaped. Before any configuration is done in ServiceNow, the team needs a shared understanding of *what problem is being solved, for whom, and why it matters*. This phase converts a vague frustration ("laptop orders take too long") into a clear, testable project idea.

1.2 Understanding the current situation

In the existing (as-is) process, a laptop order typically follows these steps:

1. The employee or hiring manager sends an email or chat message to the IT helpdesk asking for a laptop.
2. A helpdesk agent replies asking for details such as model, specification, delivery location and cost center.
3. The agent forwards the request to the manager for approval, often by email.
4. After approval, the agent manually raises a purchase request or contacts the procurement team.
5. The requester keeps asking "where is my laptop?" because there is no single place to check status.
6. Once the laptop arrives, IT configures it and closes the ticket by hand.

Every one of these steps depends on people remembering to act. Approvals get buried in inboxes, information is missing on the first request, and no one has a reliable record of who approved what and when.

1.3 Problem statement

Standard laptop requests are handled through manual, email-driven steps that cause delays, incomplete requests, missed approvals, poor visibility and duplicated effort for IT and procurement teams.

1.4 Pain points identified

Pain point	Impact
Requests arrive in different formats (email, chat, phone)	Agents spend time chasing missing information
Approvals are collected over email	Delays, lost approvals, no reliable audit trail
Procurement is triggered manually	Orders are late or forgotten
No real-time status for the requester	High volume of follow-up tickets and calls
No standard list of approved models	Inconsistent purchases, higher cost, support complexity
No reporting on turnaround time	Management cannot measure or improve the process

1.5 Stakeholders and their needs

- **Employee / requester:** wants an easy way to ask for a laptop and see progress.
- **Reporting manager:** wants a simple, one-click approval with the necessary context.
- **IT helpdesk / fulfilment team:** wants complete requests and fewer manual hand-offs.
- **Procurement team:** wants a clear, approved purchase request with all details.
- **Finance:** wants budget control and traceability of spend.
- **IT management:** wants metrics such as approval time, fulfilment time and volume.

1.6 Ideation techniques used

Several structured techniques help the team move from problem to solution:

a) Brainstorming session. The team listed every possible idea without judging it: an email template, a shared spreadsheet, a chatbot, a Service Catalog item, a full ERP integration, and a Flow Designer automation.

b) "How Might We" questions.

- How might we let employees request a laptop in under two minutes?
- How might we make sure every request is approved before money is spent?
- How might we give requesters visibility without extra tickets?

c) Mind mapping. The central node "Laptop Order Automation" was expanded into branches: *Request*, *Approval*, *Procurement*, *Fulfilment*, *Notification* and *Reporting*.

d) SWOT analysis of the idea.

Strengths	Weaknesses
Uses existing ServiceNow licences; low-code; reusable pattern	Requires clean catalog and user/manager data
Fast to build and change	Only suitable for <i>standard</i> laptops, not custom hardware

Opportunities	Threats
Extend to monitors, phones, software	Low adoption if users keep emailing IT
Integrate with vendor/ERP later	Approval bottlenecks if managers ignore notifications

1.7 Solution options compared

Option	Advantages	Drawbacks	Decision
Improved email process	Zero build effort	Same delays and poor tracking	Rejected
Shared spreadsheet tracker	Easy to start	Manual, error-prone, no workflow	Rejected
Custom-coded scripts and business rules	Very flexible	Hard to maintain, needs developers	Rejected
Catalog item + Flow Designer	Low-code, visual, maintainable, auditable	Needs design discipline	Selected
Full ERP procurement integration	End-to-end automation	High cost and long timeline	Future phase

1.8 The chosen idea

The team selected a **Service Catalog item with a Flow Designer flow**. Flow Designer is ServiceNow's low-code automation tool, allowing the process to be built as readable, ordered actions (ask for approval, create task, update record, send notification) instead of scripts. Because the flow is visual, business users and analysts can understand and review it, and administrators can modify it without deep coding.

1.9 Proposed solution in one picture

```
Employee submits catalog request
    |
    v
Request Item (RITM) is created
    |
    v
Flow Designer flow starts
    |
    v
Manager approval  --(rejected)-->  Notify requester, close request
    |
    (approved)
    v
Create procurement task for purchasing team
    |
    v
Laptop procured, configured, delivered
    |
    v
Update RITM, notify requester, close request
```

1.10 Expected benefits

- **Speed:** approvals and procurement tasks are created instantly instead of waiting on manual forwarding.
- **Accuracy:** mandatory catalog fields ensure complete information the first time.
- **Transparency:** the requester tracks progress in the portal.
- **Compliance:** every approval is recorded with user and timestamp.
- **Efficiency:** helpdesk time shifts from chasing to genuine support.
- **Standardization:** only approved laptop models are offered.

1.11 Success criteria defined at ideation

1. Requests are submitted only through the catalog form.
2. Approval is obtained automatically from the requester's manager.
3. A procurement task is created without manual intervention after approval.
4. The requester receives notifications at submission, approval/rejection and completion.
5. Management can report on volume and turnaround time.

1.12 Assumptions, risks and constraints identified early

- **Assumptions:** user records have a valid manager and email; a procurement assignment group exists; the standard laptop models are pre-decided.
- **Risks:** low adoption; missing manager data; approvers not responding. These are mitigated through communication, data checks and reminder/escalation logic.
- **Constraints:** development takes place in a ServiceNow developer instance; vendor integration is out of scope for this release.

1.13 Outcome of the phase

The phase ended with an agreed problem statement, a shortlisted and justified solution, defined stakeholders, expected benefits and initial success criteria. This gives the next phase, requirement analysis, a firm foundation.